

event that it actually pays him not to give his 100 per cent every time he competes. **Track-and-field athletes receive an additional bonus each time they break the world record.** The caveat is that you only get the prize money one time at the meet you broke it at. So, each meet, Duplantis raises the bar just one tiny centimetre. And each meet, he earns another bonus. That's why when you scroll the 'All Time Top Lists' section of the men's pole vault event on the World Athletics statistics page, you'd have to scroll all the way to No. 11 to see someone not named Armand Duplantis.

That level of dominance that's almost unheard of in track-and-field. The last athlete to have anything similar was Ukrainian great Sergey Bubka, who broke the pole vault record 35 times. But Bubka topped off at 6.15 metres. Duplantis has equalled or gone past that mark 13 times already. **Indeed, of the top 101 jumps of all time in the pole vault event (6.02 m and above), Duplantis (6.26) has 44 of those; everyone else combined has 57.**

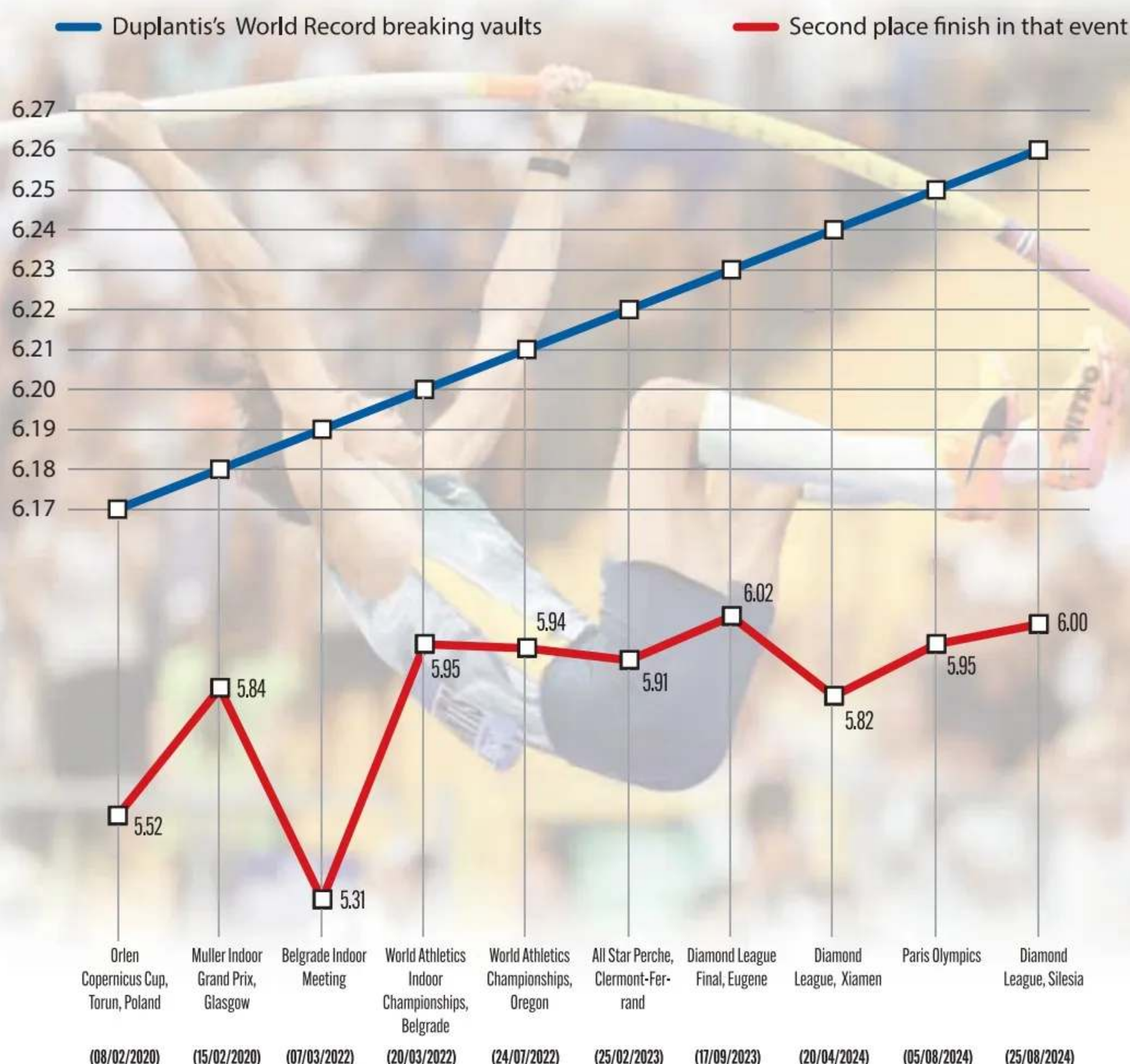
Duplantis seems like even more of a statistical anomaly when you compare his world record to the next best in his sport. The next highest

vaulter after Duplantis is France's Reynaud Lavillenie, who jumped 6.16m in 2014. So, Duplantis' record is 1.623% better than the next best vaulter ever. For perspective, Usain Bolt's world record in the 100m is 1.15% better than number two, Tyson Gay. Ingebrigtsen, who smashed the 20-year-old world record in the 3000m in Silesia, is 0.71 per cent faster than the next best runner over the same distance.

So what makes Duplantis so good?

He's that rare combination of nature and nurture. Most athletes come into the pole vault — perhaps one of the most technically

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